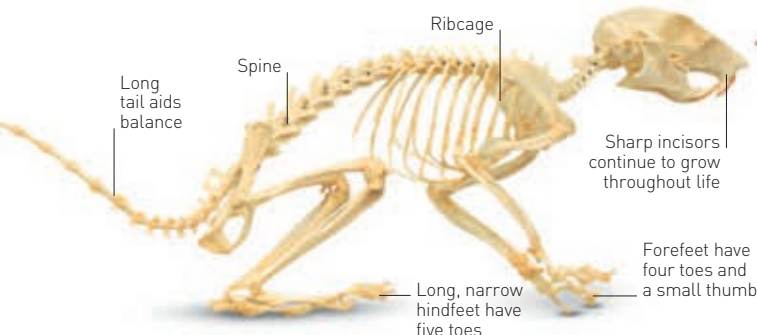


Rodents

There are few places in the world where rodents cannot live. Mostly small, these animals fit themselves into many different habitats, and often flourish in huge numbers. Rodents are gnawing animals that must constantly wear down their ever-growing front teeth.

WHAT MAKES A RODENT?

A compact body, long whiskers, and a long tail are common rodent features, although there are many variations in this big group. Rodents' teeth make them different from other animals. They have four sharp front teeth, or incisors, and just a few molars at the back of the mouth.



SQUIRREL SKELETON

SUITABLE BODIES

Many rodents have special body adaptations to suit their various lifestyles. These include extra-flexible joints in the feet for climbing trees, protruding teeth for digging and tunnelling, and webbed toes for swimming.



CLIMBERS

Swivelling joints in their ankles make squirrels one of the few mammals that can climb head first down a tree.



BURROWERS

Mole-rats dig with their sticking-out front teeth, and push the soil behind them with their wide, flat hindfeet.

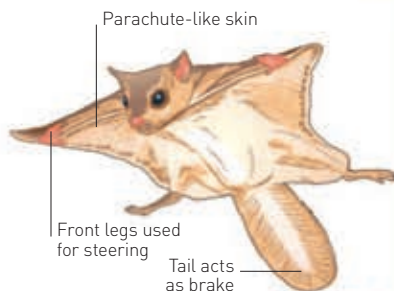


SWIMMERS

Beavers have webbed feet and a flat tail that is used as a rudder. Thick underfur keeps them warm in water.

HOW SQUIRRELS "FLY"

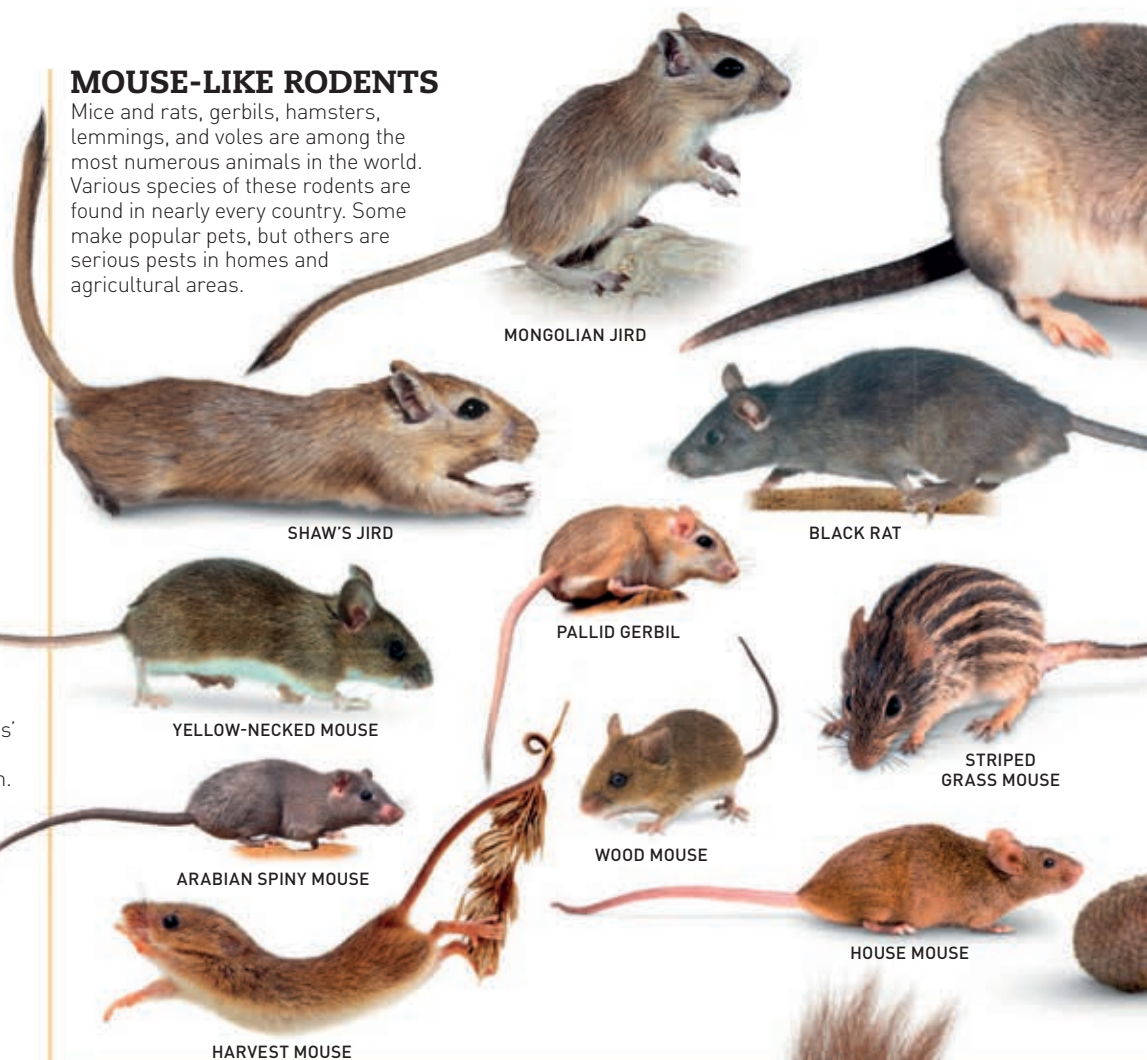
The rodent group includes the flying squirrels. As they move between trees, these animals travel through the air in what appears to be real flight. In fact, they are gliders. A flying squirrel has thin, loose skin between its legs that spreads out like a parachute to keep it aloft. To steer in midair, the squirrel moves its front legs. When preparing to land, it raises its fluffy tail as a brake.



A FLYING SQUIRREL CAN GLIDE FOR UP TO 50 M (165 FT)

MOUSE-LIKE RODENTS

Mice and rats, gerbils, hamsters, lemmings, and voles are among the most numerous animals in the world. Various species of these rodents are found in nearly every country. Some make popular pets, but others are serious pests in homes and agricultural areas.



SQUIRREL-LIKE RODENTS

Squirrels and their relatives have cylindrical bodies, thick fur, and most have bushy tails and big eyes. They are found throughout the world in habitats from rainforest to semi-arid desert to big cities. Some live in trees, others on the ground.



CAVY-LIKE RODENTS

The best known of these rodents is the guinea pig, or cavy. It has a big head, sturdy body, short tail, and slender legs, which are common features among this varied group. Cavy relatives include porcupines, the capybara – the biggest rodent in the world – and the almost hairless, nearly blind mole-rat, which lives underground.

